

Rh immunoglobulin injection An injection of antibodies given to women who have a rhesus negative blood group if they may have been exposed to rhesus positive fetal blood cells.

Rooting The baby's instinctive searching for the breast in order to feed.

Rubella (German measles) A mild virus that may cause congenital abnormalities in the fetus if it is contracted by a woman during the first 12 weeks of pregnancy.

Sonographer Medical professional who operates ultrasonic imaging devices.

Spider nevi Tiny new veins noticeable on your cheeks, breasts, and legs, required to help your body disperse the extra heat generated in pregnancy.

Spinal anesthesia An injection of anesthetic into the spine for pain relief.

Startle reflex Also known as the Moro reflex. Newborns are tested for this reflex to check the nervous system is working.

Stillbirth The delivery of a deceased baby after the 24th week of pregnancy.

Stretch marks Shiny lines that sometimes appear on the skin after it has been stretched during pregnancy.

Surfactant A creamy fluid that reduces the surface tension of the lungs so that they do not stick together when deflated. Premature babies may have breathing difficulties if surfactant has not developed sufficiently.

Suture The stitching together of a tear or a surgical incision.

Thrombosis A blood clot, commonly occurring in the calf; most dangerous if in the lungs (pulmonary embolus).

Thrush A yeast infection that can form in the mucus membranes of the mouth, genitals, or nipples.

Toxoplasmosis A parasite infection that can be caught from cats or other pets. It's also found in soil and it can be present on fruit

and vegetables. If it crosses the placenta during pregnancy, it can cause eye or central nervous system damage in the baby.

Transcutaneous electronic nerve stimulation (TENS) A method of pain relief that uses electrical impulses to block pain messages to the brain.

Transducer An instrument that translates echoes of high-frequency sound waves, bounced off the developing fetus in the uterus, to build an ultrasound image on a monitor. See also *Ultrasound*.

Transition A phase between the first and second stages of labor when the cervix is dilating to between 2¾–4 in (7–10 cm).

Transverse lie A sideways position of the fetus in the uterus.

Trial of labor A situation in which, although a cesarean section may be necessary, the mother labors in order to see if a vaginal delivery is possible.

Twins The simultaneous development of two babies in the uterus. If two eggs are fertilized independently by two sperm, dizygotic or fraternal twins result; more rarely, one fertilized egg divides to produce monozygotic or identical twins.

Ultrasound A way of building up a picture of an object by bouncing high-frequency soundwaves off it. Ultrasounds are used during pregnancy to show the development of the fetus in the uterus. See also *Transducer*.

Umbilical cord The cord connecting the fetus to the placenta.

Urinary-tract infection (UTI) Infection affecting the kidneys and/or bladder.

Uterus (or womb) The hollow muscular organ in which the fertilized egg becomes embedded. Once implanted the egg develops into an embryo and then a fetus.

Vacuum extractor An instrument, used as an alternative to forceps, which adheres to the baby's scalp by suction and helps guide the baby out of the vagina.

Vagina The channel between the uterus and the external genitals. It receives the penis during intercourse and is the passage through which the baby is delivered (also called the birth canal).

Varicose veins Swollen veins in the legs that occur late in pregnancy.

VBAC Vaginal birth after cesarean section.

Vernix A thick, greasy substance that covers and protects the fetus's skin in the uterus.

Vertex presentation When the top of the fetus's head is the part closest to the cervix.

Vulva The external part of the female reproductive organs.

Water birth Birth of a baby under water.

Yolk sac The first source of nutrients for an embryo until the placenta takes over at around 12 weeks.

Zygote The single cell, formed by the merging of the egg and sperm.